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Chuck Mancuso

Chuck Mancuso is an avid fan, supporter and observer of all styles of American music. His superior teaching and scholarship at Buffalo State College has been recognized with the awarding of the Chancellor's Award for Research, Scholarship and Creativity. Chuck is the author of the 1996 book Popular Music and the Underground: Foundations of Jazz, Blues, Country and Rock.

Chuck was interviewed in Buffalo, New York on October 10, 2013, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I am in the office in Buffalo of Chuck Mancuso. And I'm glad to be here at Buffalo State College. And I'm going to describe you as, well first of all, a professor of music, but researcher and author, and a huge fan — is that where it started, as being a huge fan — of this music?

CM: Yeah, right. It started back in the 50s, and I was just a kid playing a lot of sports and I thought I was going to be a sports writer. And I found out that this great music that I loved — you know my father had these 78s, and when we were little kids both mom and dad worked, and so they'd say on Saturday mornings you've got to be quiet, because we're upstairs sleeping in the house. So I went through his records. I mean I was what, maybe nine, ten years old. And the first things that hit me were those boogie woogie things of Pete Johnson. I'd go oh my God, this is so cool, and then Albert Ammons and the rest of them. He was a big Frankie Carle fan.

MR: Frankie Carle.

CM: Yeah.

MR: Cocktail —

CM: Right. He was very florid and fluid and you know, romantic. And my father was — he wasn't a musician, my mother wasn't a musician. No one had any instruments in the house. But I got stung. And as the years went on I started reading every book I could. And one summer I'd just read Hemingway, Storm Jamesen and a number of others that had nothing to do with music. And another summer it was all the beat generation. But other summers it was just music. Just all the things I could get on jazz and pop and everything else. And I always wondered why they never taught this stuff in school because it was so fascinating, and I had no one to talk to, there was no one to share it with.

MR: I was going to say, you couldn't have had many friends that were boys that were your age that would like go, "So what do you think of James P. Johnson?"

CM: Yeah, right. Is he a pitcher for the Philadelphia Phillies? I knew every baseball player so I was pretty good there, and you know, was a basketball kid. But I had this other passion. So on weekends I'd go to the Grosvener Library, the downtown library, and they would have these magazines down in the subbasement. And I would get them called up, and they'd get to know who I was so as soon as I walked in I'd go, "I want the *Jazz Reviews*" you know, "of all the ones I didn't read last week." And I'd take notes on them. And then the old *Metronomes*, and in those days *Esquire* wrote about jazz too.

MR: They sure did.

CM: Beautiful. One of the librarians, my girlfriend's a librarian at Buffalo State, Butler Library, they were cleaning things out and she found a number of the old *Esquires* from 1942, '43, '44. She says, "This is for Chuck, oh my God." So, you know, anything I could find I would just collect.

MR: Plus they sponsored that photo that became "A Great Day in Harlem."

CM: Oh yeah.

MR: *Esquire* magazine did.

CM: Yes. And that's after they kind of gave up a little bit on jazz, but there had to be something there that kept them with it. So here I was in school, and we were a nomadic tribe. We moved. It was like the Italians — and we weren't alone with the Italians — but my father's family, they were Sicilian, the Mancusos. And his father, and they had four kids, three boys and a girl. And they bought a house. You know, they were from Sicily. And they made sure that there was room for the sons. Okay? And as the sons got married there was a place. My mother's people were from the middle of Italy, and he was a hard working guy. You know, he used to say, "Marie, you do not date those Sicilian boys, do they not like to get their fingers dirty, their fingernails dirty." And it's true. They were slickers. The Sicilians were slickers. There were a lot of stones, you know, everybody kind of dominated, and that's where the mob kind of stuff came from. And all of those guys went into sales. They were slick guys you know. My uncle Bay, he was always a baker, and they at Kresberries, and then a buyer at Sattlers and he used to call me up, "Nef, I just got back from a slack bar, and I got a great tiger-tooth two button, and I can get you a nice pair of creased, you know with our tailor, come on down and we'll take care of it. I always just put a little money down and I always did a little extra work. And my uncle Blase, who I was with last night, he worked at A M & A's. These guys were all clothiers. And he'd go, "Chuckie, you've got to understand, "You know, Uncle Blase, "You've got to understand it doesn't matter about the first suit you sell. Anybody can sell the suit. You treat 'em nice, they come back again." That's the way he talked, I'm telling you. It was unbelievable.

MR: That's great.

CM: So I knew how to dress man. I dressed all the time.

MR: Okay. You were sharp.

CM: Always sharp. Yeah. Because of them. And Uncle Bay was pretty slick. He'd go, "You ain't no Cary Grant but you sure will be able to dress well."

MR: Was there an Italian musical tradition in your family, in the circle?

CM: No.

MR: Really?

CM: No. I know. My mother married very big on race. Oh my God. You didn't screw around with blacks. Because when I was in nursery school, she would take me to nursery school and the very next year my brother to nursery school, we were in a little housing thing. My father was off in World War II. And it was me, and this little other guy who was black, and my mother held my hand and his hand. And then two days a week the lady — right now I'm trying to remember the names, we were so close — would hold my hand and his hand and take us. And we got to be great friends throughout our lives, the kid and I.

MR: A boy? A black boy also?

CM: Yeah. We were both the same age. She would just go crazy. You know the Italians, the Italians and the Irish had this little separation and antagonism. They kind of hated each other, historically. If you read this recent book about 400 years of — a new book that just came out about Greenwich Village.

MR: I saw that.

CM: It's a great book. And it talks about the animosity. There was always that kind of animosity. And there was something about some of my people that was tough about the blacks. You know, they used to call them *melanzane* you know? That was eggplant. Because it was a shiny black.

MR: Wow. How do you spell that?

CM: *Melanzane* — M-U-L — I don't know. But my mother, oh my God, when she heard Grandpa Mancuso, a Sicilian tough guy, I don't know, he had some light mob connections. He dealt the cards for the big games on Connecticut Street. She would rail at him. She says, "We don't treat people like that," you know, about blacks, if he ever said *melanzane*. So I came up —

MR: But she didn't want you to associate with black people —

CM: Of course she did.

MR: Oh she did.

CM: She's the one that walked me to school with the black kid.

MR: Oh I'm sorry, I misunderstood.

CM: Yeah, I'm talking kind of fast. Yeah, little Buddy Clark and Mrs. Clark. Some days Mrs. Clark would take myself and Buddy and the other days, and my mother, I have an award

in her name, she was the first female manager in New York State of the Unemployment Agency and Employment Agency both, in 1947, as a woman and as an Italian woman. She was a bright woman. So she was my model on how to deal with that stuff.

MR: And you had boogie woogie records in your house.

CM: Right.

MR: Were you aware that most of those players were black?

CM: Oh yeah. Because a couple of those 78 albums had the pictures you know. Sometimes they had drawings, you know, like Fats Waller with big lips and everything. But I loved those guys, and as I read about jazz, you know, most of these guys were black, and especially the foreign writers. They were very sympathetic to that world, and very few of these guys who were writing who were American were the prejudiced ones, the early ones. So I came up reading about these guys, and then in high school, you know, it was the beat generation. And I go why isn't stuff taught in school? Man I loved this stuff. And nothing. Nothing. Occasionally I would find a friend. It was usually in theater or something. And then I came to Buffalo State, and I made all high in basketball so I was kind of coveted by a number of schools. I went to Buff State and by the third year I dropped out and came back and I started writing for the newspaper. And this one guy, Jack Lyons, had been the editor. And he said, you know, "Why don't you become the sports editor? You're always saying how come there's no pictures." I was doing photography a lot in those days. And I said, "Yeah, there's no pictures. Don't you have someone to take pictures?" Well we've got one guy. And I says, "I'll get pictures, I do darkroom work." So I started getting all these pictures, and I was the sports editor for two and a half years. And then Jack Lyons, same guy — he was a clever guy — his article was "The Lyon's L-Y-O-N-apostrophe-S Den." Jack Lyons. So he said, "You've got to write a little history on jazz, because you know everything about jazz." I didn't know anything about jazz, but I read all this stuff. I knew more than anybody else. So I wrote this Part I, Part II history, and my first article came out and so he got the paper and he wanted to see how it lined up and everything, and it didn't just say Chuck Mancuso, it said Chaz with the Jazz. I go son of a gun, I do, Lyon's Den, Chaz with Jazz, you have a way, Jack, you know. And that's what I was, I was Chaz with Jazz. And in the spring of '64, I'd just started the second semester of the '63 year, I took this course from Bill Tallmadge. And the course was called Afro-American Music. And it was upstairs in this building. He played a test. He had to put a little blockade because you couldn't see the records because they didn't have tapes in those days.

MR: Sure.

CM: And I'd know if it was Riverside, I'd know if it was Blue Note.

MR: That's funny.

CM: But anyway, he loved me. And I had a lot to learn about Gospel and folk and everything. But he said, "You know you have some good writing skills." I said, "Yeah, I'm a bad speller but I'm going to work on that." I'm going to work on the spelling. And so he had me, I couldn't get up in front of people to speak in those days. I could play in front of thousands of people. You know, that picture there — we used to jam the gym. I was the captain for two and a half years, of the basketball team and all-conference and the NEA all-American in my senior year.

MR: Nice.

CM: So I had a real nice career. And he loved to go to my basketball games. And he said, "You know on the court you're about as tall as most of the guys but you play like you're six-five." "I love you Professor Tallmadge, you're so nice." But he had me teach for one week on the Contemporary Movement, this is 1964, so something on Blue Note Records. So I did a thing with Blue Note and Riverside Records, and Art Blakey and Horace Silver and that stuff. And that was cool. So a girl was in the class and she sat next to me and she said, "You know, my cousin just signed a record contract with Riverside Records, you were talking about Riverside, and he's real big." And it was Chuck Mangione.

MR: I'll be darned. This was "The Jazz Brothers?"

CM: "The Jazz Brothers." Yeah. The first album. And you know, the Dizzy Gillespie sort of trumpeter. Well if you went through Rochester, he got known.

MR: That's where I'm from.

CM: Yeah. So you know that those guys would go for Sunday. They'd say, "You've got to make a stop at Rochester, the Mangione family will take good care of you." So she said — I said, "well let me know something about them. Bring their scrapbook and everything else." The first concert I ever did was the Mangione brothers. 196 — it was probably '65 or maybe late '64. I don't have any posters of it, but that was the first one I did. And that was the beginning of me putting on concerts and eventually doing things where I would do little workshops with each of the artists. That was the key. You had to be educational. And I came back to Buffalo — so I graduated and I was going to be a writer. I worked for the *Courier* as a summer sports replacement, and in 1966 I graduated, and I sent to all these Canadian colleges, because they weren't very good. We'd always play one Canadian college at the beginning of the season. We played Toronto, Western Ontario, and one other one. And those coaches I wrote to and I said I want to do my graduate work in Canada, because I know that I'll be able to play as a graduate student for two years. This was heaven. I mean there was a high scorer in Western, New York, Conesus, Niagara, the whole bit. So I wasn't quite good enough to be in the pros, I didn't have the ABA at the time. When we scrimmaged with the Buffalo Braves, my team scrimmaged with the Buffalo Braves for three seasons before they went to camp, they had Randy at

that time, and guys like Dave Roll and Bobby Weiss and those guys, "How come you didn't play with the ABA?" They didn't have an ABA. And it turns out I couldn't go to the college. I had a scholarship from all of them and I wanted to go to McGill, because I spoke a little French, because to me that was as European as you can get, you know, up there in Ottawa. And they didn't have any of it. So I had a scholarship there and then right before I was going to start I get this letter. Now this is the summer of '65, *Time* magazine did "The Summer of the Viet Nam Graduate." So I had two courses left to finish. And I was just finishing up and I got this September 1st — so I ran down to Board 85. I was always great with ladies, you know, talking to adult ladies you know, because I was interested in what they had to say. My mother taught me to be a nice little boy. And I thought, I said to this lady, you know, "You've got to understand, I have a scholarship, wouldn't it be great? I can play ball for two years, you know?" She says, "Son, don't you understand what's going on? All these young men are going to Canada to get away." And I said, "I'll sign anything. I don't want to stay in Canada, I just want to play basketball for two years, I'll have a master's and I can get my writing career." She looked me straight in the eye and she goes, "Son, September 1st, a nice toothbrush, a clean pair of shorts, you're Board 85's number one." So a guy I played ball with, Joe Lotempio, he started at Baker Hall now in Buffalo, he used to tell you, "Now if you don't behave yourself we'll send you to Father Baker over the bridge. Because that's where they send the bad boys. Now I had been in exceptional education. I got out once my writing got better. And I had a couple of the English profs say don't even go to Syracuse. You just keep writing. You have a nice style. And I thought I was going to be writing. And then Joe Lotempio said — he started in June at Baker Hall — and he said, "You're going to be a dead writer." He just picked me up by my neck. He was a strong guy. He said, "I'm taking you into Baker Hall. I'm going to show you a room where you're going to teach." I said, "I got out of Ex Ed." "You're going back in Ex Ed." This will get you out of the draft. Because you won't have to fight, to go to the war. And that's why I got back into teaching. I'd never done teaching. I had three kids in my room, and after two and a half classes they ate me up and spit me out. And I told my parents, they went crying and yelling. We had out first house on Lancaster Street, and I said, "I can't do it." She goes, "You were a counselor at the Butler Mitchell, those kids were tougher than those kids, you just — you're not going to go — you're not going to go to that Army." And my brother had to go, my younger brother. He went right around that time and he got fucked up in Viet Nam, I've got to tell you. Excuse my language. You know, beautiful kid, oh yeah. He used to send me little tapes about how crazy it was. He was a photographer too. He worked on it. He said, "I'd be in the back and they'd have these cannons all over, an ear went flying by, some brains hit me in the face, and I had to take these pictures." And

he says, "I told them, I don't want to do it anymore." So anyway, so I did all kinds of teaching there. And then I came for my master's and Tallmadge asked me to do review classes in 1969 in the library. And they loved what I was doing.

MR: And what was your master's in?

CM: My first master's I had a fellowship here in '69-'70 in Ex Ed. So they paid for everything, it was great. One of the guys at Cole's said to Dr. Dobby, he said, "Charles, you're in your third year of teaching at Baker Hall. You know you've got two more years to get the master's." I didn't even know this guy that well. And he said, "I worked on something. I have a fellowship for you. Twenty-six hundred dollars, all books are paid for, you have your little apartment, you won't have to worry about that, you do all the testing in the campus school here on campus." And so I did that and Tallmadge had me do the review classes. They were averaging four people in the library. I got them up to 80. Because I knew how to teach by then, and I knew how to get them ready. And they gave me a full time job in 1970, '71, in the music department across the street, Albright. And it was amazing. I was teaching in a big round building. And I had like 180 kids in each class. But I was used to teaching these tough kids. So I didn't have to worry about screaming. I'd say, "Young man, put that down. You're not going to drink coffee in here." He said, "What are you, John Wayne?" "I'm not only John Wayne, you'll be out of this class, one more word like that." Because I don't need to have that, you know? No food and drink, and this was in a big room. And I did great. I mean I just — I had such fucking energy. I would get up at two, three in the morning, you know, and I'd have three screens. There was only two of us at the college who were teaching three screens. There was a guy named Francis Lestingia and me. And my whole goal was to always do a three screen lecture. And that took so much time. It was unbelievable. So I developed that. And that's how I started.

MR: Well let me ask you about a few things. In your book *Popular Music —*

CM: *And the Underground*.

MR: *And the Underground*. Because you said some really interesting things. One thing I liked that you said, a lot of people like the phrase "jazz is America's only original art form." And I used to — I think when I read that when I was younger I go yeah, yeah, yeah. That's cool. That's great.

CM: You believed it. Of course.

MR: It sounds really good.

CM: I know.

MR: And then you start thinking now wait a minute. Where did blues come from? And where did rock & roll come from?

CM: And where did bluegrass come from?

MR: Where did bluegrass come from?

CM: You know, I was Chaz with Jazz. That's what I believed too. But you know, through Tallmadge, Bill was this amazing, gentle, tall, bland-looking Nebraskan guy, you know? But he had been on the road with the bubble guy.

MR: Kay Kaiser?

CM: No.

MR: Oh Lawrence Welk.

CM: Lawrence Welk. And Lawrence Welk, that's when he had a little bit of a jazz group. And Bill played some jazzy stuff with him, you know. I don't think he recorded. But, so when he did his studies, you know, he really started with hymnody, white hymnody, and shaped-notes singing, and spirituals and Gospels with blacks. And then he was big on folk music, you know, the Song Catchers and all that. This was a side I didn't know about. So he would take me to Springville. I mean I'm a West Side kid you know. We'd go to Springville and we'd go looking for these records. And we would go to these holiness churches and he'd take me to black churches and white churches and when he'd take me to a black church, everybody's black. And here comes this pale, tall man. And I had some trepidation, you know, but I guess he knows some of these people. And they'd open the door and we'd go walking in and they're pounding the tambourines and everything and they'd go, "Professor Tallmadge is here." It was a white man who teaches at the university center who thinks what we do is significant. Was that something. And they froze. They'd go "Oh Professor Tallmadge, how are you doing?" "Oh fine." You know, he didn't talk real loud or anything. And he said, "Would you play something for us?" And he'd sit down and he'd play a Gospel tune and they just went crazy because this white guy, who looked so square, could do this stuff. And I was astounded. Because I really couldn't play it or anything. I mean I eventually took some piano lessons.

MR: Could you join in from even just a clapping your hands —

CM: Oh sure.

MR: Okay.

CM: Oh yeah.

MR: And did you feel compelled to do so, because of the music? I mean —

CM: No, not to show them that I could do off-beat stuff.

MR: Okay, that's my question.

CM: No I was so respectful. I'd stay out of the way. Because he was the show. I was just a sidekick. They didn't know who I was and they didn't really care. They figured I probably was his son. So I was an adjunct to him. He was the one. When we went into some of the white churches the same kind of thing happened. And so I learned all this stuff because of Bill. And he'd give me his notes, he'd show me how to do it and I'd go

visit him all the time. I remember him telling me one time Coltrane was in town and I called him up and I says, "McCoy Tyner just took a twenty-one minute solo." I used to time everything you know. And he goes, "I can't do it right now, Chuck, because I'm teaching country and folk and my whole head is in country and folk." I didn't understand it at the time. But he did his intro courses, which were the big draws, like my jazz-rock, now American popular music is a big draw. And then he did this special course, which was, they didn't have writing intensive, but you had to write essays and stuff. So when he was in that, you know, he stayed in that. And then when he was doing the modern jazz he'd come and see Coltrane with me and Miles and all these guys. So he was an amazing man, the fact that he would constantly call me son, and when I replaced him, I came back, because 1970 and into 1971, Rockefeller left the governorship, and all of a sudden all that money — you know we had people that went from instructor to full professor in like three years. And you got stuck with these people. It was almost too good with the money for education. That's how strongly he believed in education. So they had to let me go in 1971 because they didn't have the money. I was the last hired, first let go. But I kept teaching summer courses and a night course in what we now call an adjunct, while I was at Baker Hall. So when he retired I did my interviews. They didn't want me because, as great as I did, we had Peter Yates, who wrote this book on American music, a very important book on American music, there was a lot of classical music, Peter Yates, and his wife was a world interpreter of Charles Ives. They were very important out in California. And our department hated this guy. Because he didn't play music. He was a literature writer about music. His wife played music. He was a great writer though. He appreciated me. But they had to let me go. So now I come back from my interviews, and they're pelting me with these questions, because they didn't want me, most of them. They all liked me, because I didn't spit at anybody. I wasn't a horrible guy. But I wasn't one of them. And Tallmadge said, "There's no one in America can do what he's doing right now, are you kidding? He's way beyond all the other guys. They have bigger names. He works at this 15 hours a day." He had to give me some time to play basketball six nights a week you know. But I really did work hard at it. And it looked good, that I was going to get the job. And Mary Fiore, who always came at me, says "Well what would you do if you had to teach theory." She didn't say, "What would you do, Chuck, if you had to teach theory." She had this nasty way about her. And I says, "Well, Mary, I wouldn't be able to do that, because I'm not trained for it. But let me say to all of you, if you had to teach Urban Blues and Rock, I can assure you, if you're not up on what Led Zeppelin had been doing, or some of these other groups, it's not like teaching about Mozart in the old days where you can get away with making a mistake. They will know. You will be found. And that's dangerous. And you have to know what you're talking about. And I can do that

pretty well. So I had the job pretty much, and then I'll never forget, I got a call over at Cole's. And there was one more guy they had to interview. And Tallmadge, he goes, "Chuck, I've got to tell you, this crazy guy came in from New York City, his name is Brown, he's written two books, he has a doctorate, you only have a master's, and I know you're working on" — I finished the second master's in film theory with Jerry O'Grady over at Media Studies. And I did a lot of things on music, film music and blah, blah, blah. He said, "I told them, we haven't seen this guy teach. Let him teach a class to us." "No, no, we want him. He's got all the ingredients." So I didn't get the job. So I go back to Baker Hall. And it turns out I get a call, Peter Yates was still there by the way, hanging by a thread. And now it's the second week of school and Jerry Close comes over and we're going to run around the track at Buff State, and we're getting ready for basketball you know. And he says, "Oh by the way, you got a call from a professor at Buff State." I said, "Okay, I'll look at it, let's do the run." Now it had already been two and a half weeks teaching in the City of Buffalo. I'd leave Baker Hall, I thought I'd try something different, with Ex Ed. I met with the families and they loved me and I loved them. It was a nice situation. And Peter Yates goes, "Well we have to tell you something, Charles." This guy Brown, you know we're over here on Elmwood Avenue in the Albright Building, and he's teaching where I was teaching. None of those people ever came over there, because it was too far in a round building. He hadn't been there for two and a half weeks. We don't know if some angel of a secretary didn't send him the contract, or he just took another job and thought they were jerks, he never showed up. He says, "We're in a bind." Now Bill is in Berea, Kentucky, where he had a chair at a school for mountain children where Bradley Kincaid went and had a great collection of the Carter family. I called him up, I says, "They offered me the job, but they only offered me one year. I'm making sixteen and they're offering me twelve." And I was making eighteen and they were offering me twelve. This was back in 1976. He says, "Don't worry about the money, you'll make it up, but don't take a one year contract. They'll be interviewing for your job while you're teaching." So I tried to get a three-year and they only gave me a two-year. He says, "That's okay, they will not — you've got it down." Because I'd been teaching all those summers and night classes with him. I team taught with him for five years as well, until he left. And sure enough I got the job. And every summer Bill would come, Bill would come to visit me for four, five days, and stay with his son, and I'd have him tell the story about how this guy tried to fire him when he wanted to teach this music.

MR: That's great. Well let me follow-up on this.

CM: I'm sorry. I'm very long-winded.

MR: No that's fine. This art thing. What has to happen for an American popular music style to get to the level of being considered an art form? I mean jazz did. Is blues an art form, and why so?

CM: Well I don't know what the parameters of how you define an art form, but I think when more and more historian/critics start doing real heavy research and they see there are connections to many other areas, not necessarily Matisse and the French Impressionists movement, because these were mostly uneducated guys and gals doing blues. But the fact that the records were important. Today they call it roots music. I was calling it underground music. But it's all underground, you know, building up. So I think when the historians and the cultural critics start picking up the momentum of something that they didn't even know about, a lot of them, or someone like Charlie Keil. When Charlie Keil did his book on urban blues, and you had these other, Samuel Charters and the rest of these guys who really elevated Mississippi — you know, John Hurt and all those older guys — and then those historians put down the city guys because they were unkinking their hair, they were ironing their hair, they were wearing shiny suits and they were playing, and they were plugging those God damned instruments in you know, and they were making a lot of noise, and they were putting that stuff down. And what Keil said, he was a sociologist in Chicago at the time. Anthropology, sociology. And his book, *Urban Blues* was the key. He said those older guys, you know, unless the performer was broken down and had barely a tooth in his head, was playing not even that well but had made records in the twenties, they were authentic. But Muddy Waters, you know, and Howlin' Wolf, and these guys in the cities making this loud music as they plugged the things in, they were putting those people down. That's not folk music. Well it was urban folk continuum. And I remember B.B. King said, "Thank God for Charlie Keil." And when Charlie did a lot of stuff, he moved to Buffalo, and he wrote my Foreword. And we shared the same birthdate, August 12th. He said we were star-crossed. So every birthday, we started at my house, with martinis and beer, and then we went to his house, for the part II. It was like a caravan. Because he did a lot of playing in music. You know he put together a group with hands-on stuff, and he ran the American Studies program over at U.B. And we actually did the first transfer of us. I went to U.B. to teach those students in his program, American Studies, about the history of what I do now. He came over to Albright Hall and he did the hands-on stuff for the kids, playing all these marimbas and stuff, and shakers. And when he left U.B. he said he had a great point. He said, "I'm tired of fighting the windmills of academe." And he retired to Connecticut. I shed many a tear when he left. He was one important person. But that whole idea of, when the critics and historians start really paying attention to this stuff, and they see — and the better writers like Peter Guralnick, how they use that imagery of the highways, you know. When I do

my rock & roll class we do the lost highways. You know, here's what these guys were traveling. Then you had the white guys, Merle Haggard and these guys who went out to California, you know, first picking grapes and then potatoes, and then you had the black guys who were going to their various places, first Chicago and then later California. And then you have Charles Brown and Nat Cole. He could play piano. And they had those independent record companies. Oh my God. What a world. And I get to teach about it. And when I did my — all my concerts that I did, I did this with a couple of students when Elvis Costello, Buffalo State Loves Jazz, all these things. Steve [s/l] Rebufsky. And we were doing this stuff in '76, '77, '78, '79. And I always made sure we did workshops, you know, and that we brought in the critics. We brought in Stanley Crouch — I just got his new book, you know, *Kansas City Lightning*, the study of Charlie Parker and Kansas City. Gary Giddins. Ira Gitler. Don DeMichael. I brought them all in. 1978. And then I did 1979, we did another thing and I brought other critics in. Ben Sidran and the Heath Brothers. And I made sure I brought in Jackie & Roy and, I forget who the other one was, the electric guitar player, his wife wrote a book about him, one of the first fusion players, oh I can't think of his name right now. And then I started doing these other projects you know. And I always made sure the education was there. Who were writing the books and who had the magazines. Galen Garth. He got all of those old *Cash Box* magazines and he got the rights to them, so I have all those things that he left for me, it was really nice. Terrific.

MR: In your book you have a lot of detailed charts about record sales and so forth. In your mind, can you pick out an artist that you think whose record sales are justified, whose talent is justified by record sales. Who is an artist that comes to mind?

CM: Nat King Cole.

MR: Nat King Cole.

CM: Right off the bat.

MR: Okay.

CM: You know Alabama, went out there, even whitened his face, oh it was terrible.

MR: When he played in Alabama?

CM: No. At one point before he got to California, it was so hard for a black man in the deep south, as you can imagine, he had to whiten up, he thought. Oh it's scary. There's a documentary that shows when he was doing it. But when he went out there, and you know, Central Avenue, and all he did with those early records was just play jazz. Cab Calloway claims that he tried to convince Nat that he had a little stutter and he was embarrassed to sing because he couldn't really. He says, "You stand in front of a mirror and you pronounce the words slowly. And you will be able to improve your diction." I

don't know if that's all he did, but I'll tell you he was one of the most articulated singers in the history of American pop music.

MR: You know just on the way here today, I don't know if it was the Buffalo station or Toronto, they played him singing "Stardust." Good Lord.

CM: Wasn't that amazing?

MR: So I'm glad you picked him.

CM: You know, and what I didn't realize, that he wanted to live in Hollywood. Because he was out there, Capitol Records, you know, the house that Nat built. And he had moved into this neighborhood, and it was all whites. And so the people came to him and they said, "Listen," you know, "we've got some problems here." You know, blah, blah, blah, blah, blah, blah, blah. They didn't come out and say that he was the problem, but he knew what they were talking about. And Nat said, "Well you know, my wife and I meant to talk to you people about this." You know, he goes, "Some of the people are leaving their garbage out and this is a really ritzy neighborhood, and so I hope we're going to put some of that garbage away because we like it here and we're not moving."

MR: He headed them off at the pass.

CM: He made these records of his hits in Japanese, in Spanish, in French, in Italian. He couldn't speak them. But he must have worked so hard on his diction that he could learn the words — not read the stuff — he learned the words and then he would take trips to all these places. That's how rich he got. We didn't know anything about it. I didn't know anything about it. It was unbelievable. What a remarkable guy.

MR: What about the opposite. Is there someone that comes to mind that you think had minimal talent or individuality but managed to really be at the top of the record charts?

CM: Well Paul Whiteman got a raw deal I thought, you know, the "King of Jazz." I thought they treated him, a reverse discrimination. Because that's not answering your question, but they treated him poorly. Because he had great jazz players in his group and he had two things answered. I always have my students take a look at Duke Ellington and Paul Whiteman. And one of the things that my book is trying to show is objectivity. You know Whiteman didn't stretch to do what Ellington did. And Ellington didn't get quite the popularity that Paul Whiteman did. But the critics, especially the jazz people, took these rotten shots at him, Whiteman, as in white man robbing the world of jazz. And this idea that blacks own jazz — nobody owns jazz, you know. Most of the players got — because if you're going to say that then these black men should not be able to play classical music. If you're going to use that —

MR: Or basketball?

CM: Huh?

MR: Or basketball?

CM: Sure.

MR: I mean that's pretty ridiculous, isn't it.

CM: Of course. And it's nasty thinking number one, and it's limited thinking number two. And one of the things I've tried to show in our world is that, you know I told the class, now we're going to go to country and folk. Now for many of you, you're from the northeast, and you're going to think this stuff is not so great. But I want to show you some really great artists, and today they are treated that way. But they weren't during their lifetime. And it took a while for some of the younger historians to come in, like the Greil Marcuses, like the Nick Toshes, like the Peter Guralnicks, to really show — now my mentor was doing it. That's why I'm lucky. So I came up with him and I learned about it. I didn't really have an opinion, I just didn't listen to it. And once he got me there and we talked about it all the time, I'd go, what a great man. What a gentle spirit, to not be so obnoxious as this stuff sucks and this stuff is — so that's what that book tries to just show the people, and you don't have to like the stuff. And I tell the students, I said, you don't have to know all those charts. I didn't write a textbook. I wrote a source book. So it just shows you the enormity of this stuff. And I'm always fascinated by how much was out there.

MR: And I'm fascinated by the — you had one chart, it was almost like a poster, and it said King Records. It was a thing for King Records.

CM: Oh yeah.

MR: And it said "We sell in all three fields: Hillbilly, Pops and Sepia." And it's so informative to see that language.

CM: Yeah. Because Cincinnati was, like a border town. They had the black part of town on one side, and they had the white part, so you had Moon Mulligan and Hank Penny and his Radio Cowboys, and then they had Wynonie Harris Going Wild. And oh my God.

MR: And here's a statement you have regarding Benny Goodman. "That Goodman was white and more palatable to the dominant white pop audience should be of little surprise. Even while making a radical shift popular culture seizes upon that which is most accommodating and secure."

CM: Yeah. Well I think that was part of the culture at the time you know. That's all. But you know, he brazenly went ahead and he brought in Teddy Wilson. You know, it helped that John was pushing, Hammond was pushing him all the time. But he was a Jewish guy. So he understood it a little better. I always felt that Sicilians understood that stuff too. Because we were swarthy and dark and curly-haired, my people. You know, we had been run over and run by all these other people, which I didn't know at the time, but when my mother wouldn't allow us to speak Italian, she said, "Trust me, I know why I'm doing it." Because when she came up, her father, they used to make fun. And he was from the

northern part. Grandpa Giorlamo. They would make fun of him. Oh, you know, where's your accordion? Where's your Neapolitan hat? You people smell funny. You do all that. Oh yeah. It was not so nice. And with Sicilians it was worse. It was worse because the Sicilians had an attitude. You know they were run over by the Swedish — the Swedish folks came down and ran the country. And that's when they had Godfathers. I mean I don't approve of any of that stuff, but — and I got stories you see, from my grandfather Mancuso. He was one tough SOB. I didn't like him at first. But he'd go to the ballgames and I'd have like maybe 33 points against — I'll never forget it — against Fredonia, and I had a cousin who was going to be playing in another year, he was a freshman — at 33, at home, and there was nine minutes to go. And he took me out and wanted one of my other pals to play. And my grandfather would sit behind the back of the coach and he'd get up, "What are you doing taking the kid out? You don't want him to score too many points, huh, he's Sicilian. You white son-of-a-bitch." I'd go, grandpa, grandpa, what are you — calm down. "You could have had 45 points."

MR: He's my family.

CM: Oh he was tough.

MR: That's a good story.

CM: Yeah.

MR: I wanted to play — you remember *DownBeat* magazine used to do the blindfold test.

CM: Oh sure. Leonard Feather and the great blindfold test.

MR: Well this isn't exactly that, but I just picked out a couple of pieces of music —

CM: Okay.

MR: And I wanted to get —

[audio interlude]

CM: It sounds like the Ensembles Dixie Style.

MR: Yes. It's King Oliver.

CM: I was going to go from the Dixieland Jazz Band would play a little sharper and faster into someone like him, or — Jelly Roll didn't quite do that kind of stuff. But yeah, that little shaky clarinet and stuff. Yeah. Great ensemble stuff, with Louis playing second cornet.

MR: Okay. So if we go from this group —

[audio interlude]

CM: Is that the Whiteman with Bix and the boys?

MR: Yup. "Singing the Blues."

CM: Oh yeah. That's Trumbauer playing right now.

MR: Yes.

CM: Because in class I just play his last five notes, and then we listen to the great solo of "Singing the Blues" by Bix. And then I do Vince Giordano replicating it a hundred years later and everything.

MR: Why in your estimation are those records so different?

CM: It might be because it was such a separation of white and black. And the cool nature of some of the players, which they didn't call cool at the time, but there was a more melodic kind of approach. And it had to do with race at the time but there were some great, hot players who were white. But to me, Bix, I love that stuff. And I love Louis' stuff. The King Oliver stuff was a little, I don't think I'd say sloppy, but it was different. And there was a certain kind of articulation that some of these guys brought into the music. And some of the historians took them to task for it, but then you have a genius like Louis. I mean he just, he just cut right through a lot of that stuff.

MR: He blew it open.

CM: Yeah. It was just amazing what he did.

MR: It's funny, how could you criticize a style that was developing. It's like they're criticizing it because it didn't end up where Louis took it.

CM: Right.

MR: They set him up, it's like they set him up to blow it up.

CM: Yeah. And plus he had the great chops, you know, he's going to hit these high C's and he had the energy to lift a God damn rocket ship. So why not? I mean the guy — you know I show them the clip of him doing one of these songs, and I go, "This guy was smoking weed before every show, and it's supposed to be mellow. You know, I mean look at him. He can't even stand still. He just can't wait to take a solo. He's just so full of energy and imagination." And we're all richer for it.

MR: I guess. Do you think Bix is put higher up on a pedestal because he is one of the few white innovators, or do you even consider him an innovator?

CM: Oh he was — the stuff was great. I mean Sudhalter makes a great case in his book, you know, about the whites. And even Nick LaRocca — you know there are more Italians down in New Orleans at the turn of the twentieth century, at the beginning of the twentieth century, than there were in New York City, even though we all came through Ellis Island. Because the French owned it, the Spanish, and then the French a second time. Catholic. And in New Orleans a similar atmosphere, weather. And there were all these Italians there. Thousands of Italians. And LaRocca always said that — he took them to task. He said they never gave the Italians enough credit for what we did, all right? They were great players. Opera. I know the first opera houses were in the Creole section in America. But great players. And you know when I saw the history, Ken Burns jazz was correct. Ken Burns' vision of jazz. And he didn't use enough, in terms of historical

stuff, of Gunther Schuller. Schuller had it right. He was using a little too much of Wynton and, at the time Gary Giddons, but especially Stanley Crouch. I call him Stanley Grouch. I brought him up here. What a pain in the neck, but what a funny guy.

MR: Really. A pain in the neck and a funny guy?

CM: Oh yeah. He's a grouch. He thinks he's got all the answers and everything. So I remember I had Mark Murphy singing with Sonny Rollins. And he comes behind, in the room behind, while Mark is singing, doing a whole tribute to Miles and to Clifford Brown. And he goes, "So what's this guy got on Joe Williams?" Like that. I go, "What's he got on Joe Williams, they're friends. Why? What's the problem?" "He ain't got nothin' on Joe Williams." I said, "well he scats a lot better than Joe Williams, but Joe has this beautiful baritone voice and everything else. And I don't know that they're in competition except with you." And I invited these guys to my house and everything. And I had done a lecture/presentation of jazz singing. And he and Giddons and Gitler and one other guy, came to the talk. I did a three screen lecture. And we were talking about different styles of jazz singing. It was right on. And they walked out because they wanted to get some food. I said, well, what do I know, because I'm only from Buffalo, and you are the mother-fuckers from New York City. And believe me, I knew ten times what Giddons knew back then, and then same thing with Crouch. Because they were off-base on a lot of things. I had Al Tinney here. And Al Tinney was the one who ran those things at Clark Monroe's. And he made his home here, and he was a gentle spirit too.

MR: Yes. I did an interview with him.

CM: Oh, so you know. He would never brag or anything else. And so Ira sees Sammy Noto and sees Sam Falzone, who just died last week —

MR: Oh.

CM: Yeah. Sweet. He was in a Hospice. And he goes, "Chuck, is that Al Tinney?" I go, "Yeah." He says, "I'm working on my second book on bebop. You think I can get an interview with him." I was thinking if you weren't a friend of Carleton's I'd say go fuck yourself. But I didn't say it. I treated those guys great. I had great sandwiches in my house. My mother — and he was a funny guy, I've got to admit. But yeah, so Gitler did this nice interview with Al, and did a 2-1/2 page part of his second bop book about that. So Gitler liked ice hockey. He was a big ice hockey guy. But anyway, they treated Mark real shabby. He's a faggot with a bad wig.

MR: Oh. We should know better.

CM: I know.

MR: Okay, try this one on.

[audio interlude]

CM: Mama Thornton. 1952. Lieber and Stoller.

MR: Isn't that great?

CM: And you know when Elvis did it, he did a great job, but it was a whole different thing. You know, he isn't singing about the same thing she's singing about.

MR: I just think it's so — you know this is a different recording than another one I had because she actually, the music actually gets turned around, the beat. Or she comes in, you know, the 12-bar form gets a little askew, the way she's singing it. But you know what, it doesn't matter at all.

CM: No. Oh, no, no.

MR: She's like, Big Mama, do what you wanna do.

CM: I like, what's his name, "Bear Cat" The answer song that Thomas did.

MR: Yeah, I actually have it.

CM: Yeah. See Elvis of course, he's singing about a little hound dog you know, and playing with the little doggie thing.

MR: Yeah, with the little hat on.

CM: Great interpretation, taking it a whole different way. You know it has nothing to do with what she was singing about.

MR: Was that on purpose?

CM: You know, Lieber and Stoller talk about when I think one of them was on one of these ocean liners and it went down.

MR: The Andrea Doria.

CM: The Andrea Doria, right. And so the one of them, I can't remember if it was Jerry or Mike, was on the ship. And so it went down as the ship was coming in. And I know they lost a lot of people. And he goes oh my God, I hope he's okay. And as soon as he got there, oh thanks, blah, blah, blah. And then he tells them, once he tells him he's alive, he goes, "Hey by the way," you know, "we've got a big hit." He goes, you know, because this was a couple of years later after she did it. He goes, "Yeah, it's 'Hound Dog.'" He goes, "Mama Thornton!" He goes, "No, no, this new guy, Elvis Presley." He goes, "Elvis Presley's got a hit?" He goes, "Yeah." He goes, "We've got a number one hit. We're going to get some nice royalties out of this." And so, you know, they kind of put him down at the time because you know, it was just this kid with the hair and everything. Well when Elvis started doing the films he wanted Lieber and Stoller to write for him for all those films. That was great, because it was like eight, nine songs a film, and what Jerry said, and in the recent book that came out, he said, "we thought we were the hippest white kids in America." You know, "we were dating black girls and everything. We had the jargon down" you know. "We wrote for the Robins and Charles Brown." And he says, "This guy knew more about black music than we did." Because he grew up in

Memphis and he would go see uh, what's his name, the guy who did, the black piano player who married the one girl and slapped her around, oh God.

MR: Not Ike Turner?

CM: Ike.

MR: Ike Turner.

CM: And Ike used to leave, it was in the black section of town, because he was always going down to the black section of town without telling mama. He goes, boy there was an alley in this place where Ike was playing in the afternoon matinees. And he would open the door and Elvis then could peer in and watch him play the piano. And he says, "Oh we knew Elvis was a hip little cat, man, at that time, he just loved our music, he loved our music." And so he knew about white Gospel, black Gospel. He knew about the great singers like Billy Eckstine and the Ink Spots. He was hungry for music. You know? So he was a lot hipper than people give him credit — he just was not an articulate guy. But he had absorbed all this stuff. And when Jerry Lieber said that, he used to say, "Listen, we thought we were ten times hipper than him. When we worked with him he was just a teenager, you know, rock & roll pop star, but we had some real doubts." Not intellect, you know, like a well-read person, but a sound person. So they were quite surprised after working with him.

MR: What do you think about Colonel Tom Parker?

CM: Oh well, he's just a character. He was making money.

MR: Yeah.

CM: You know, when he worked with Eddie Arnold, he only worked with Eddie Arnold. When he worked with Hank Snow, he only worked with Hank Snow. And then Elvis was one of the openers and I guess he saw him at one of those little airport things and — the guys didn't get pissed off that the girls were in love with him. They said wow, I want to dress like that. I want to do something like that guy. He's different than us. And we think we're rocks and everything, but look at the style this guy's got. And that's unusual. You know, I just did a thing on Sinatra. When he was the first teenage star and he was singing all these beautiful ballads, you know, at the Paramount, and the girls are screaming and yelling, "Violets for Your Furs" right? They were still screaming when he'd do something like that. Those young guys hated that. They hated it. A skinny kid with a bow tie you know. But he reinvented himself and, you know, the Ava thing went, he lost his voice, he made the comeback after "Mama Won't Bark" with Mitch Miller. And then all of a sudden he started doing these albums with ties down, you know, before "Only the Lonely." You know, a drink in his hand. And what was it that Scott Fitzgerald said, "No second lives in America." He reinvented himself. All of a sudden now here is a guy that these guys, when they were younger, suddenly thought were really cool now. How many

times has that happened? You know? He was something. My people loved him. Oh my God. When he played Buffalo, you could hear the jewelry being put on by his Italian women, from blocks away. "I don't care," the wives would tell their husbands, "I don't care, you're getting me tickets to the Memorial Auditorium. I don't care what it costs, you take out a loan. You're out there with the boys drinking, you're doing this, we're going to see Frank or you ain't getting sex for the next month."

MR: Tell me about some of your most memorable moments in the jazz clubs in Buffalo. I mean is there some night, some artist that stands out in your head?

CM: Oh my God. First time I went to the Bonton on Waverly Street on the east side, it was just like a typical New York or New Jersey bar on a corner. You walk in, there's a long bar, there's a back room where you might have a fish fry, etcetera. Well they had put up a little stage this high, so they could get some outlets in. And this seems to be — there was no ad for it, I somehow found out the Three Sounds — Gene Harris and Simpkins and Dowdy were playing. And I was taking piano lessons at the time. And Tom Jones, he was the sixth man. He could always get in free, and I'd give him these blind passes. And he was taking piano lessons. One of us loved Les McCann and one of us loved Gene Harris and we'd talk, who was the funkiest of them. So we'd have these fights. So I said, "Well let's go see my man Gene, because he's playing with the Three Sounds at this place and we'll find it, we know where the hell it is, it's on East Ferry. How hard can it be? They had the piano, they didn't even have that set up yet. That's how, this piano, was right on the floor. And they came out, three of them. And I looked around, it's 9:30, there's only like five people in the joint. I was to find out that the black audience comes out a little bit later. 9:30. So we're right next to them, and it was an old piano, and he was hitting the keys so hard that a couple of the — you know it was not a good piano and these keys were like flying, ivory was flying — not a hundred of them but you know, five or six of them. I go, he's beating the piano fucking up, Tom, look at that. I know Les is good, but look at this. And they just, I mean I was just blown away. And if he was here, we were here, I love him. Holy smokes. And then I met him and I interviewed him a little bit. And when he came in to the Royal Arms, which was a bigger club off of Main Street on West Utica, I think he wanted to work out and we had a trainer named Tony Sartori who also loved jazz. And I called up Tony and I says, Tony, these guys, a lot of them come in from out of town and I ask them if they're athletes or anything and they didn't have health clubs in those days, you know you had to go to the YMCA if you weren't a member. So he said, "Charlie, you know I like the Three Sounds, bring him down, I'll get him in the gym and we'll do some stuff." And Johnny Lytle was like that too he had been in Pittsburgh, sort of a boxer or something like that. So I got Johnny Lytle in there. And there was a few others too, just because of our connections upstate. Of course Coltrane

was, and you know Elvin Jones and McCoy, and Jim Garrison and stuff. And I was just doing some interviews of my dear friend who I spent a lot of time with whose name was Paul Gresham. He had a group called Birthright. And a little bit later in his group he had Ricky Ford.

MR: Ricky Ford?

CM: Joe Ford?

MR: Ricky Ford plays tenor.

CM: The one that went to play with McCoy Tyner. Joe Ford or Ricky Ford.

MR: I think Ricky Ford. I'm not sure.

CM: Well whoever it was. And Paul looked just like McCoy Tyner. And as it turns out when he got on the road a little bit, we started trading records, as kids just out of high school. I just happened to meet him and he was with his cousin and two other black kids. We were cabbages. And we started, oh yeah, yeah, oh yeah, yeah. You collect records? I go yeah, I've got a lot of records, like maybe 15 hundred at the time you know, in high school. And he played a little bit, of piano, but saxophone. And so I remember the first time we met, on Delavan, on the east side of Delavan in the black community. And we went to his cousin's house. And they told me to bring a couple of records, we were going to trade. So you'd get a couple of records you'd heard over and over again and you'd see what he's got. So we hit it off real good. And he lived on Florida Street. So I would go to his house on Florida Street, and his mother was really fabulous. And then he'd come to my house. And he loved my mother. In fact he had her spaghetti sauce recipe, her coleslaw with pineapple recipe, and a few others. And so we loved each other's mothers and we were there all the time. So he had got to meet McCoy in New York. So now this was the second time that Coltrane came in. So the first time I didn't talk to Coltrane, you couldn't talk to Coltrane, he was very serious and in bad shape. But this time he goes, "Charles, you're going to love this, we're going to sit with Trane in between every set, you and me." He says, "I told him I got the hippest white boy in America. He knows more about jazz history than I do." So there I was with Coltrane. Well he was having the teeth problems you know, with the sugar. He had a lot of sugar things. But we talked to McCoy. I was going you know, "Is that an e minor vamp" you know because Paul had shown me how to do a little bit of the "My Favorite Things" which I would play over and over, not well at all. And then Jimmy was nice to talk to. Elvin was just sort of aloof. But in between every set, for six nights, it was just remarkable. It was unbelievable. It was fabulous. And my non-interview with Thelonious Monk, we had a black kid who was a bad basketball player, Jimmy something, and he happened to be a worker at the Royal the hotel that was right next to the Royal Arms, it wasn't called the Royal Arms, it was called the Stratford Arms. So when these guys opened this one time, Cleaners, it was a

big Cleaners, it was a jazz night club, they called it the Royal Arms and they created a shield, you know with two blades crossing, R on one side and at the bottom was A. And there was a stage that you walked up five steps to, and it was like a semi-circle. It had a semi-circle bar and there was a space between the edge of that stage and where the three cash registers were. And you could actually fall off that stage if you got too far into the stage. And you walked up those five steps to get on the stage. So Jimmy said, "Charlie, Charlie, I talked to Nellie (the wife of Monk) and I told them I've got this white kid who really knows a lot about jazz, and could he get an interview?" And she says, "Well you know I think so, maybe Friday night. Tell him to come before the 9:30 show." So I came at 8:00. And so he was there. I said he's got to be there. And he goes "Oh don't worry I'll take you up and I'll introduce you to Nellie." So he knocks on the door, "Nellie, this is Chuck," you know, our basketball pal and a jazz guy. So is Monk ready to do a brief interview with Chuck?" So I had a whole bunch of questions. And she goes, "Well I'm not so sure right now." So she goes to ask Monk. "Thelonious, the young man is here." Dadadada. He's on the bed. And so she opens the door and she goes, "You know, Chuck, I don't think he's going to do an interview tonight." She opened the door so I could see, he is doing a simulated backstroke as if he's swimming. Like this. And he's not stopping. I guess that was a message that he was not going to do an interview. So Jimmy looks at me and I go, "we tried. It's okay." I always have this story.

MR: Yes. It makes for a good story. And today's his birthday.

CM: Oh really?

MR: Yes.

CM: Well I'm so glad that his son picked up the mantle after trying the rhythm & blues world for a couple of years. It's just like Natalie Cole. You want to do what your father did.

MR: Yeah. Speaking of that, Ravi Coltrane came to Hamilton once. And he looked so much like his father. And I was sitting next to him and it was a very weird feeling.

CM: Eerie, huh?

MR: Because I had to remind myself, this is the son. Because he's sitting there with a tenor sax. Well we're about to run out of tape here. But I wanted to — one more chart you have, Mainstream Stars from 1900 to 1950 and Underground Stars.

CM: I did one of those?

MR: Yeah you did. Under Mainstream Stars we have, I counted this, there was like 15 white people and almost all male. And under Underground Stars there were 12 black people and 5 white people. Does that say something?

CM: I don't know. I don't know what I was thinking. What were they, Ruby Braff?

MR: Well these were no, big names. The big names. People who we'd recognize. And I wasn't going to draw any conclusions from it. But it just seemed like if a fellow like Stanley

Crouch said that the white musicians had absconded with most of our musical styles, is he correct in that, in your estimation?

CM: Oh I don't know. There's a sensitivity on his part. I mean he's always been contentious about some of the whites. And you know, a lot of the people that owned the record companies were white. And I think they felt more comfortable dealing with them, some of them might have been prejudiced, I mean I don't think that Norman Granz was, and I don't know about Gibson, with Concord, his tend to be white, with Betty Carter and a couple of the others. But that was a while ago when I did that, so I don't —

MR: Well you didn't say that so I don't want to put that spin —

CM: It wasn't done consciously. I don't know why I chose who I chose. I can't even remember what I did back then.

MR: Do you find that there's an interest — oh how do I put this — I'm disappointed when I see hardly any black audience coming out to like blues events and jazz events in Utica.

CM: Oh yeah.

MR: And it's like where are they and why don't they have an interest in this music.

CM: I think it's a lot of lack of education, I really do. I don't think they have — they haven't taken many courses in anything like this, and — because I have black kids come and say man I never heard this kind of music. Because they're into rap and hip hop, and it's a faster pace and it's — and history is a pain in the ass to most of these people. You know they take my course because it says pop. Or before it was jazz-rock foundations. And there's a sense that these courses are — because if it's not in their major it's going to be a gimme course. A course should not be as hard as anything you take in your major. And this should be a fluff course. And then they get to me and half the class is getting an E on all my first tests. And they're not that hard, and I have the stuff on Angel, we have review quizzes for them, I have review sample questions, and these are the same things that are on the test. They just have terrible study habits. And I don't mean just the black kids, the white kids. And the black kids, they never heard of who Louis Armstrong was, unless their parents were kind of hip and were big on education. And then there are some really sharp black kids around you know. We're very white in our department. We get some black kids but — you know in the old days, I'll tell you something, a couple of my friends, Chuck Domenico and Larry Bynum who was black, and this other guy, they used to go to New York City and they would get us some cream of the crop kids. That's when Steve Rubufsky was here and his whole crew. I mean they were the sharpest kids I ever had. And those guys, when they left Buffalo State, they stopped sending people out to New York City. And they find that they can make as much money from some of these kids who are deprived or whatever and they get financial help to come to the college, and we're getting a lot of these kids. And it isn't all their fault, but so many of the white, and

so many of these kids coming to the college don't belong in college. You know? And there's a lot of support at Buffalo State and this was a very black dominated administration at the high end, when Muriel came in and you had to be very careful what you said. I remember Don Metz, who runs the stuff over at Birchfield, he's an avante garde player, he's a fabulous fabulous person, probably the best friend I have here. That's why I do a lot of stuff with them. And he always cooked a lot of food. Great food. So there's a guy, Stanley Durell, Buckwheat Zydeco. So he had this thing, this menu, some of this administration was going to come to this, this Buckwheat Zydeco menu. And all of a sudden without checking, the president and three or four of the people wanted diversity, started making phone calls and took him to task for this racist thing he was doing. And I said, "Pardon?" I said, "Do you have any idea who Buckwheat Zydeco is?" Fuckers. You know? They're so ready to jump. So it's a dangerous thing with jazz.

MR: Yeah. And academia too.

CM: And academia, and you have to be very careful and I just try to say let's stay objective.

MR: Well it's been my pleasure. We're about to run out of speed here, so.

CM: Thanks, you're kind.

MR: It was very interesting for me.

CM: Well thanks.

MR: I'm glad we got to meet. Keep doing what you're doing.

CM: Well come on by again and we'll let you stay in the Mark Murphy room.

MR: Cool.

CM: You won't turn gay, believe me.

MR: Thanks a lot.

CM: Well thank you, very much.